REVVING UP FOR ELECTIONS

HOW THE BJP LEADERSHIP IS IRONING OUT GLITCHES IN THE STATES GOING TO POLLS WHILE ALSO GEARING UP FOR MISSION 2024

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The clangour in the background—the awful sound of an alliance breaking, the footfalls of central sleuths—spoke of a battle of attrition. Not exactly tense, but taut with action, and without a lot of room for missteps. Nitish Kumar, Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal (United) chief, had just gone back to a friend-turned-foe-turned-friend. And CBI teams, playing in perfect time like a crack percussion section, had descended on the premises of five Rashtriya Janata Dal leaders, including two Rajya Sabha MPs.

This is a fairly accurate freeze-frame of the state of play as the BJP primes for the 2024 polls. A curious dichotomy attends to the situation: the big picture seems comfortable enough, with the Opposition taking the field in a state of disarray, but the details hold not a few devils for the ruling party. Some crucial NDA alliances from 2019—the JD(U) in Bihar and the Akali Dal in Punjab—no longer hold; others, such as the Shiv Sena in Maharashtra and AIADMK in Tamil Nadu, are depleted. In Maharashtra, the faction headed by new CM Eknath Shinde has formed a government with the BJP but is in a legal tangle with the Thackeray group over control of the party and its symbol. And in Tamil Nadu, the AIADMK is a shadow of its former self after the assembly election defeat and factional battles.

The next one and a half years leading up to 2024 are crucial for the party elsewhere too, with 11 states up for the hustings. The BJP has the most to lose. It is in power, alone or in alliance, in eight of these states: Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh, Tripura, Meghalaya, Nagaland and Mizoram. There loom states of potential gain too: the BJP is the principal opposition in Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan, and has made inroads in urban Telangana. There's also a buzz that Jammu and Kashmir will go to the polls by year-end.

This is the context in which the drama in Bihar was unfolding. Soon after news came of the raids on its Rajya Sabha MPs Faiyaz Ahmad and Ashfaque Karim, the RJD started demanding that the new *mahagathbandhan* government ban the CBI from any operation in Bihar without permission. Some 10 opposition-ruled states have opted for such a status, but Nitish